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The TrustMRR Power Law

What 1,000 Indie Startups Reveal About Who Actually Wins

DATA FROZEN 30 JUL 2026 · 1,000 STARTUPS TRACKED

Made with GAMMA

The Cold Open

Top 10 startups earn more than the other 990 combined.

61%

Revenue Share

The top 1% of startups capture 61% of all \$334M in total revenue.

\$334M

Total Revenue

Across all 1,000 startups in the dataset.

10

Top Earners

Just 10 startups out-earn the remaining 990 combined.

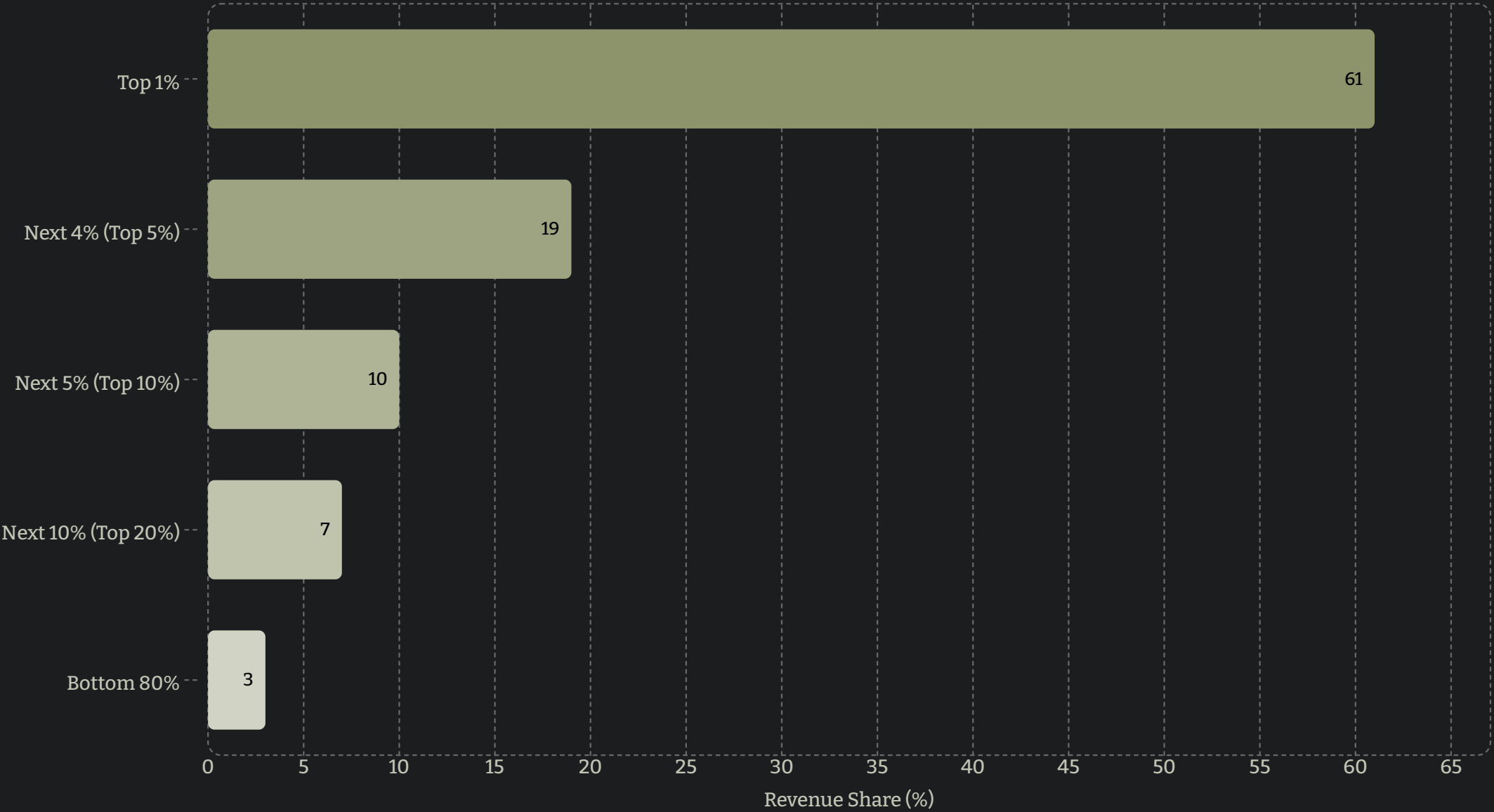
This isn't a bell curve. It's a cliff. The data reframes the entire indie startup landscape around inequality, not averages — and that changes everything about how we interpret who's winning.



The Shape of the Market

A Pareto breakdown of revenue share by percentile reveals just how extreme the concentration is. The top 1% alone commands 61% of total revenue. The top 5% control 80%. The bottom 80% of startups split the remaining sliver. This isn't gradual decay — it's a near-vertical drop from the elite tier to everyone else.

Segment



The top 1% earns 61% of all revenue. The next 4% (top 5% overall) adds another 19%, bringing the top 5% to 80% of total revenue. The next 5% (top 10%) contributes 10%, and the next 10% (top 20%) adds 7%. The bottom 80% of startups share just 3% of the \$334M total — a near-vertical drop from the elite tier to everyone else.

What's Missing From This Data

The Data Gap

24% of listings are missing every qualitative field at once — value prop, problem solved, pricing, persona, audience, and category. Essentially just a name and a revenue number.

The Stealth Twist

131 startups are literally named "Stealth Company" or "Hidden Business." One of them alone made **\$11.3M**.

Missing data here isn't always failure — sometimes it's a founder hiding a win. Treat missing data as a signal, not noise.

- ❏ The single highest-value addition for a future data pull: **launch or founding date**. Without it, "time to first dollar" or "time to monetize" cannot be computed honestly. This is the one thing we genuinely can't tell you from this dataset.

Who's Winning: Country

United States

70% of all revenue from 258 startups. Geography still matters, even in a borderless SaaS world.

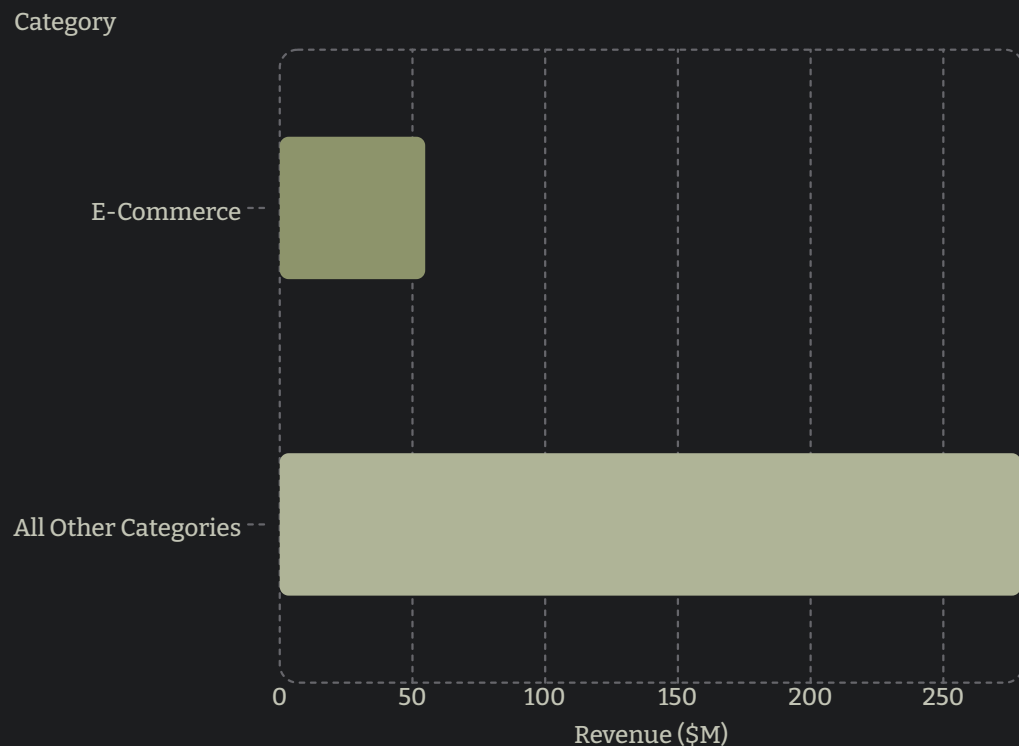
Rest of World

The remaining **30% of revenue** is split across all other countries in the dataset.

Despite the promise of a globally distributed indie startup ecosystem, the US dominates revenue generation by an overwhelming margin — 70% of all \$334M flows through 258 American-founded startups. Geography still matters, even in a borderless SaaS world.



Who's Winning: Category

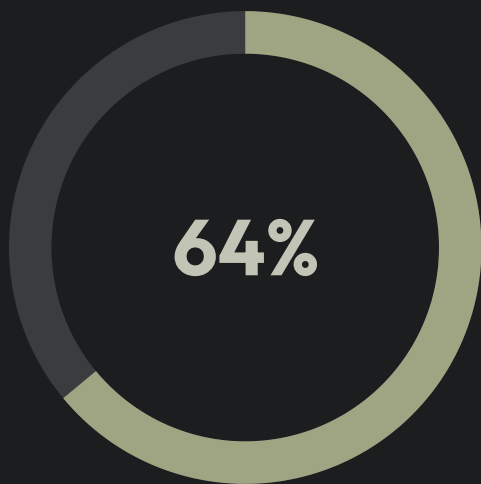


Everyone's Building AI. The Money's in Commerce.

AI wins on volume with **197 startups** — the most of any category — but **E-Commerce** wins on revenue, generating **\$54.8M from just 19 startups**. That's nearly \$2.9M per startup on average, far outpacing AI's per-startup yield.

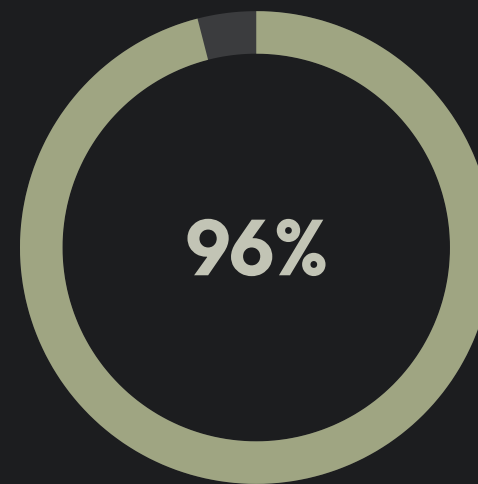
The data suggests a clear pattern: founder enthusiasm is concentrated in AI, but buyer willingness to pay is concentrated in commerce. Volume and revenue are pointing in opposite directions.

The Payment Rails



Startup Share

64% of all startups in the dataset use Stripe as their payment processor.



Revenue Share

96% of all \$334M in revenue flows through Stripe-powered startups.

"If it's not on Stripe, it's probably not making real money yet."

The gap between Stripe's 64% startup share and 96% revenue share is stark: non-Stripe startups represent over a third of listings but account for only 4% of total revenue. Stripe isn't just the dominant payment rail — it's a near-requirement for generating meaningful revenue in this ecosystem.

The Uncomfortable Middle

20% Earned \$0

In the last 90 days, one in five startups generated zero revenue. These are active listings with no recent traction.

10% Never Earned a Dollar

One in ten startups has **never** earned a single dollar — not in the last 90 days, but ever. For every "Stan" making \$76M, five startups are earning nothing.

The ecosystem has a long tail of stalled or pre-revenue founders. A fifth of the market is generating no income, and a tenth has never crossed the first-dollar threshold — worth investigating why so many are stuck at zero.

B2B vs B2C, Audience Myths & The Exit Market

B2B vs B2C

B2B median revenue is roughly **4x higher** than B2C. Consumers churn. Businesses pay.

The Audience Myth

Followers show **almost zero correlation** with revenue. MRR and subscriptions do. Your following doesn't pay your bills — your product does.

The Exit Market

26% of startups are listed for sale, with a median ask of **\$35K** and a long tail up to **\$10M**. One in four founders is already looking for the door.

Three uncomfortable truths emerge: B2B outperforms B2C by a wide margin, social following is a vanity metric with no revenue correlation, and more than a quarter of founders are actively seeking an exit — suggesting many see the ceiling earlier than expected.

Key Takeaways

1 Revenue is winner-take-most

Not evenly spread — the top 1% captures 61% of all revenue, and the top 10 out-earn the other 990 combined.

2 US + Stripe + B2B is the highest-probability combo

This combination dominates the revenue charts across geography, payment rails, and business model.

3 Audience size is a vanity metric

Traction metrics — MRR and subscriptions — are the real signal. Followers show almost zero correlation with revenue.

4 A fifth of the ecosystem is stalled

20% earned \$0 in the last 90 days; 10% have never earned a dollar. Worth investigating why.

5 Missing data is a signal, not noise

Some of the best performers are the ones hiding — 131 stealth-listed startups, one of which made \$11.3M alone.